

2.6 Unit 2, Option D: The British Empire Challenged

Focus

Grounded in an understanding of the relevant chronology, this option concentrates on key developments in the relationship between the United Kingdom and two of its most prominent and significant colonies, with a particular emphasis on understanding in some depth how nationalist ideas and movements challenged the existing nature of the colonial relationship and how the UK responded to these challenges. It gives students the opportunity to understand how economic, social, cultural and political factors affected changing relationships and how, and to what extent, partial or whole independence was intended to resolve conflict.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option D are required to study ONE topic: D1 or D2.

D1 Britain and Ireland, 1867-1922

- The challenge of nationalism, 1867-85: agricultural depression; land reform; violence; the roles and importance of Michael Davitt and Charles Stewart Parnell; land legislation and the response to nationalist activity.
- Home Rule objectives and unionist responses in Britain, 1886-1914: Gladstone's conversion to Home Rule and impact of Home Rule on UK politics; Parnell's leadership and fall; impact of Home Rule on British politics, 1903-14.
- Divisions within Ireland on Home Rule and independence, 1886-1914: the emergence and significance of Sinn Fein and Unionism; the roles of Arthur Griffith and Edward Carson.
- The parting of the ways, 1916-22: Irish responses to the First World War; the Easter Rising; proposals for independence and the division of Ireland; the roles of Lloyd George, Michael Collins and Eamonn De Valera; the Government of Ireland Act of 1920 and Anglo-Irish Treaty of 1921; the Civil War of 1922 and the creation of the Irish Free State.

D2 Britain and the Nationalist Challenge in India, 1900-47

- The importance of the Indian Empire to Britain: politically, commercially and culturally. British rule in India, c1900-14 and its impact on Indians and the British living in India; the Morley-Minto reforms.
- The significance of the First World War on the relationship between Britain and India: the impact of the Rowlatt Acts and the Amritsar Massacre on Britain and India; consultation and conflict in the 1920s and 1930s.
- The rise of nationalism in India: development of Congress and growing importance of the Muslim League; Gandhi, Nehru and Jinnah to 1939; attitudes towards nationalist ideas and independence both among the British in India and the indigenous populations.
- The impact of the Second World War; economic and political imperatives in Britain and India driving independence; the role of Mountbatten; the decision to partition and the immediate consequences of that decision.